

not say, because I can base my view on no more than one complete personal experience. To me, that notion seems symbolic of the more comprehensive view that is generally taken of the relations between the representative of the industry (practical, ignorant) on one side, and the intellectual (bookish, theoretical) on the other. That view is in its turn a cliché. Of course it would be fatal for, say, a historian to think that a historical film is the place for him to apply the most delicate results of his scholarship; but it would also be wrong for him to think that, as expert, he will be confronted by uninformed people waiting to be enlightened by him. Nor should he be overly impressed, as intellectuals often are, by the idea of the industry-man's "practicality." In fact, interestingly enough, the mutual attitude of the two may be one of unwarranted awe, until the ice is broken and large common areas are discovered. The academic mind may prove as practical and concrete as anybody's; while on the other side, the way in which certain people in the trade—art directors, say, or costume designers—document themselves in their fields, may seem like a professor's dream in its diligence and enthusiasm.

The first condition for a successful relationship is that each of the two knows what the other wants. Why are experts hired? One version is that the producers want to feel "protected": that the historical allusion, the armament detail, the duelist's motion, or whatever, will bear the stamp of specialized approval. This attitude is largely fictitious, unrelated to actuality; for the producer knows very well that his historical reconstruction is not going to be exact and "scholarly" and, which is more important, that there is no reason why it should be so. A film is being made, not a contribution to a journal; the requirements are those of the film as a coherent artistic whole. Therefore also, in order to be of any use at all, the technical adviser should keep thinking that he is, in however minor, indirect, and peripheral a way, contributing to the making of a film.

I admit that my own example—a Roman play by William Shakespeare turned into a motion picture—is a singularly happy

one because it offers the most glaring case of art prevailing over historical reconstruction. The moment we stop and think, if nothing else, that those ancient Romans speak English blank verse, we have a wide basis upon which to build as "unhistorical" an edifice as we may wish. This, in fact, could be sufficient artistic excuse for having Shakespeare in modern dress. But here a peculiarity of our own age is felt, of which the very existence of someone called "technical adviser" is a symptom. If ever we adopt modern dress we still do so with the feeling that we are being strange and *avant-garde*; we cannot be casual about it as, for example, Renaissance artists were about dress in the Biblical scenes they painted, or as Garrick was in the balcony scene where he looks like Casanova. The mentality of our time is different. We are under the impact of scientism and the history method.²

With MGM's *Julius Caesar*, although I knew that John Houseman, its producer, had staged it once in New York in a "modern" version (with an implied parallel to Fascist situations and emblems), I soon found that the motion picture was going to be in Roman dress. How historical would it have to be? In such a situation it is up to the taste and imagination of those who produce the picture to decide what the function of historical reconstruction should be and to what extent their freedom of choice should be limited. Once it is decided to have the characters look like ancient Romans, I suppose two main dangers have to be avoided: glaring anachronisms on one side and standard film "Romanism" on the other. Possibly the spectator of the film *Julius Caesar* will be so taken by the exceptional quality of the directing and the acting that he will forget about "background," general atmosphere, style, buildings, objects, props. These are the special province of art directors, costume designers, property men: of that score of individual specialists who appear so justly admirable to the layman. It is also mainly here that the technical adviser exer-

² Even a novel that had the qualities and intentions of *Forever Amber* was preceded by painstaking "research" in the period. We have in historical works, even more than in ordinary fiction, the phenomenon which Oscar Wilde, in his well-known dialogue by that title, denounced as the "decay of lying."